

Digital Photography

Taking Pictures? Experiment!

 Don't always stand upright when taking pictures. Experimenting with your posture, and the position in which you hold the camera. Get it lower, position yourself higher, dive to the side, etc, and see how your pictures turn out. With a digital camera, it costs nothing to experiment!

The Flash

 Most inbuilt flashes do their job for about 12 to 18 feet. Beyond that, they are just not powerful enough.

▣ Set the ISO (or ASO) setting to around 400, so that the flash doesn't need to work as hard. The trade-off will be a few artefacts—akin to the use of higher-speed film in a non-digital camera. Generally speaking, a higher ISO (or ASO) setting makes for better pictures in dim light.

However, do not use the highest ISO setting all the time since higher the ISO, the more the artefacts, and hence, the grainier the picture.

▣ Do not stand in front of a reflective surface such as glass or polished doors, when using a flash. The flash reflected creates a very bright reflection and thus, spoils the image.

▣ If there is a reflective surface around, stand at an angle from the surface, so that the flash reflects away from the camera.

▣ Decide when to use a flash and when not to—especially indoors. A low-contrast picture without flash is often preferable to the jarred, high-contrast pictures obtained if you use the flash in certain situations.

When On Vacation...

 Remember to carry everything you need: a charged battery, a spare battery, a charger, a spare memory card, and anything else you can think of. For example, make sure your memory card is empty before you leave.

▣ Keep a soft cloth as well

as a lens-pen handy, and remember to clean your lens regularly—preferably daily.

▣ Do not carry a brand new camera on a trip unless you are familiar with the controls.

▣ You need not reach your destination before you start clicking—it's a great idea to take pictures along the way, beginning as soon as you leave home, so you can later

The Rule Of Thirds

 This rule has been proven to result in better-looking, pleasing pictures. It goes something like this: mentally divide your viewfinder (or LCD screen) into three parts, both horizontally and vertically. Also, imagine lines—two vertical and two horizontal—demarcating these parts. Now, place objects of interest at the points of intersection of these

her interesting moods and angles.

▣ Natural light is best for portraits. This includes both, outdoor sunlight as well as that coming through the curtains. Direct sunlight is not advisable—the perfect lighting would occur in the shade of a tree or building, for example. This is also good from the point of view of the digital camera—it will not have to deal with extremes of light and dark.

▣ Backgrounds distract when we are talking portraits. Hence, set your lens to wide aperture and the zoom to high, to get the background out of focus.

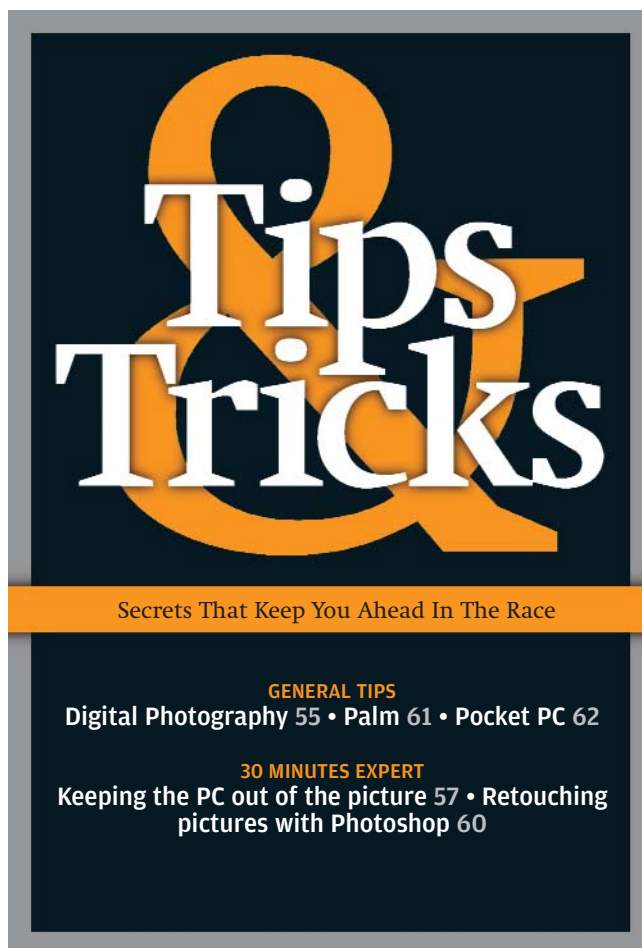
Sports Photography

 'Shutter lag' can be a problem with sports photography. This is the time between when you depress the button and when the photo being clicked. Those one or two seconds can be vital as you shoot a game. Therefore, shoot a test photograph and note the shutter lag: depress the button fully, and observe when the photo actually gets clicked. Now that you know the lag time, be prepared when you take the actual photo. It takes time getting used to it.

▣ You can also depress the shutter-release button halfway while you are still composing. Thus, you can snap quickly when the moment arrives—you will not have to depress the button entirely.

▣ Use the compressed JPEG format instead of uncompressed formats such as TIFF, although the latter give better quality. As it is, the digital camera's CCD (Charge Coupled Device, which is a type of imaging sensor used in digital cameras) takes some time to 'wipe off' a picture and move on to the next one; it takes longer if the image is larger. Thus, you may miss out on some of the action, if you snap using the TIFF format continuously.

▣ Similarly, when you use the flash, it takes some time before it charges up for the next picture. Hence, do all



compile a 'digital photo diary' of your trip.

▣ You never know what may look interesting in a new place. You might have heard of a tourist attraction, and your first impulse might be to go ahead, face it and click. Resist the temptation to do so—try and find a unique angle to snap it. For instance, a marketplace that looks chaotic and uninteresting while you are in it may make a charming picture when shot from above. Keep trying unusual angles.

lines in the photograph. Take two pictures of a similar scene: one following the rule of thirds, one not following it—and observe the difference. Of course, the rule of thirds is only a guideline. It is not a hard-and-fast rule.

Portraits

 Digital cameras are ideal for portraits. Shoot several poses and see which one is the best instantaneously.

▣ Know your subject. This is important to capture his or